

BRIEF

UK Veterinary Market: Consolidation & Active Buyers

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VETERINARY SECTOR BRIEF — UK VETERINARY MARKET: CONSOLIDATION & ACTIVE BUYERS

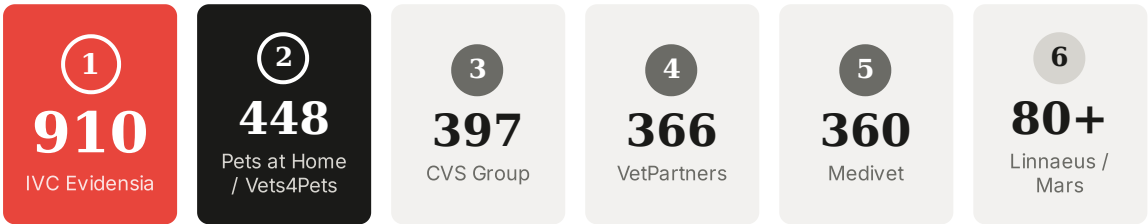
77%

Practices under group ownership by June 2026

UK first-opinion veterinary care has become a highly consolidated corporate market, and with 77% of practices under group ownership, regulation is now shifting toward transparency and pricing controls rather than structural breakups.

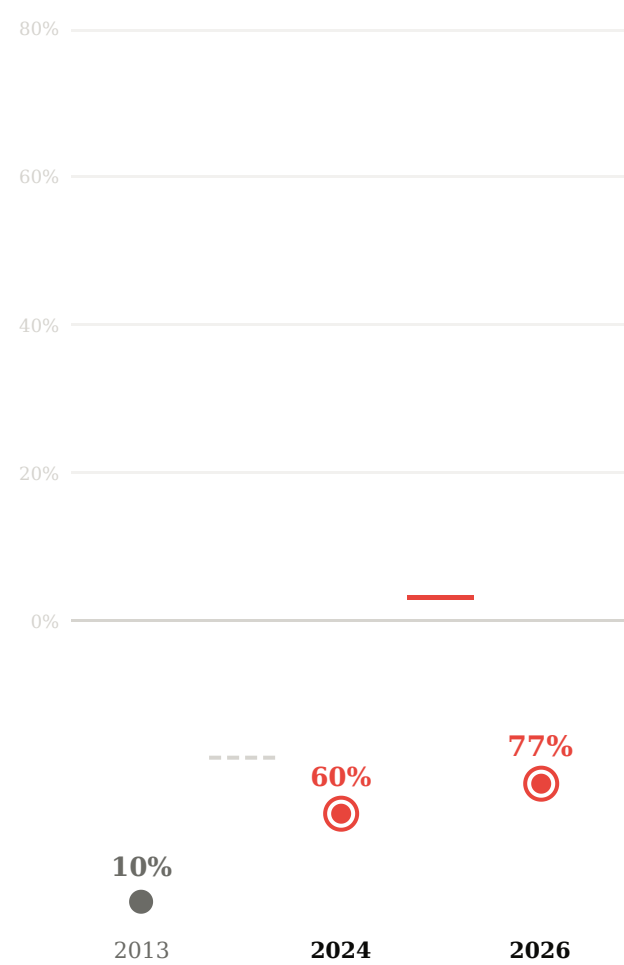
Six corporate groups surged from 10% to 77% UK veterinary market share in just 13 years, leaving fewer than 1 in 4 practices independent.

UK PRACTICE COUNT — CORPORATE GROUPS RANKED



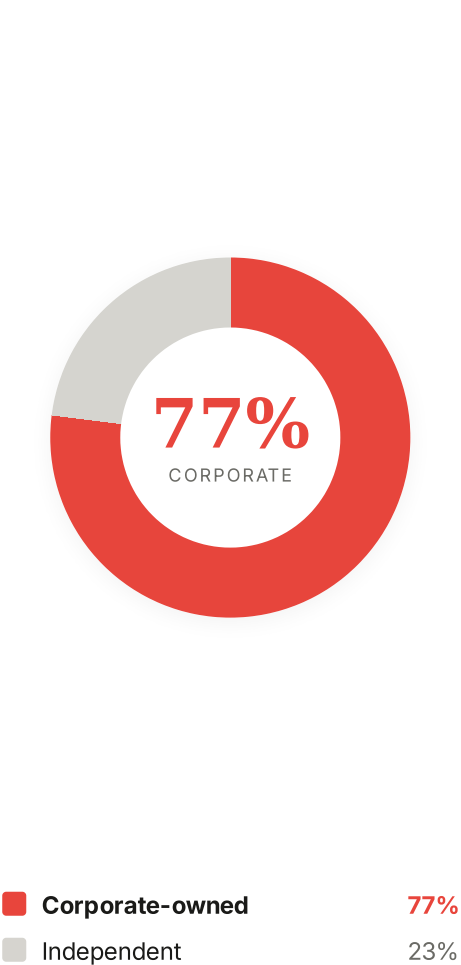
IVC Evidensia operates 2x more practices than its nearest rival — dominant by scale

CORPORATE MARKET SHARE GROWTH



6x growth in group market share over 13 years
CMA investigation triggered when share reached 60%

OWNERSHIP SPLIT 2026



Fewer than 1 in 4 UK practices remain independently owned

01 Market Consolidation Snapshot

UK first-opinion veterinary care is now a majority-corporate market: Rightvet mapped 4,826 active UK first-opinion practices in June 2026, of which 3,730 were group-owned, implying roughly 77% corporate and 23% independent ownership ¹. The CMA's market investigation found the six large veterinary groups already accounted for more than 60% of UK practices by 2024, versus about 10% in 2013, confirming a decade of rapid roll-up and materially higher concentration ^{2 3}. The market remains fragmented below the top tier, but concentration is highest in local catchments rather than nationally, which is why the CMA focused on transparency, pricing and medicine remedies rather than structural break-ups in its March 2026 final decision ^{2 4}.

02 Major Corporate Groups Benchmarked

The major UK groups remain led by IVC Evidensia, with the CMA citing 900 UK first-opinion practices in May 2025 and Rightvet mapping 910 in June 2026; Pets at Home/Vets4Pets follows with 445 FOPs in May 2025 and 448 practices in FY26, while CVS, VetPartners and Medivet each operate at several-hundred-site scale and Linnaeus remains smaller in first-opinion count but strong in referral and premium clinical positioning ^{1 5 6 7 8 9 10}. Ownership models differ materially: IVC is backed by EQT and co-investors, VetPartners was acquired by BC Partners in June 2024, Linnaeus is part of Mars Veterinary Health, CVS is LSE-listed, Pets at Home uses a 50/50 JV-led model, and Medivet is backed by CVC with an increasing branch-partnership emphasis ^{5 11 12}. Strategy has shifted from pure roll-up to selective density, clinical capability and retention: Pets at Home is still opening and extending JV practices, Medivet is pushing co-ownership, Linnaeus emphasizes referral-led quality, and CVS is allocating more incremental M&A capital to Australia than UK companion-animal consolidation ^{6 13 8 14}.

Title — Overview of Major UK Veterinary Groups: Ownership, Scale, and Strategic Approaches

GROUP	UK PRACTICE COUNT	OWNERSHIP/BACKER	CURRENT STRATEGIC READ-THROUGH
IVC Evidensia	910	EQT-led private ownership	Largest scale; selective bolt-ons, broad ecosystem
VetPartners	366	BC Partners	Multi-species platform; integration and operational focus
CVS Group	397	Publicly listed	Lower UK M&A intensity; capital tilted to Australia
Pets at Home / Vets4Pets	448	Publicly listed; JV model	Organic rollout/extensions, partner-led ownership
Linnaeus / Mars	80+ practices	Mars Veterinary Health	Referral-heavy, premium clinical positioning
Medivet	360	CVC-backed	Partnership-led model, selective UK growth

Source: Caspr analysis.

IVC Evidensia**910****Pets at Home / Vets4Pets****448****CVS Group****397****VetPartners****366****Medivet****360****Linnaeus / Mars****80+****OWNERSHIP TYPE**

■ Private Equity (EQT)
 ■ Publicly Listed
 ■ Private Equity (BC / CVC)
 ■ Corporate (Mars)

03 M&A Activity and Active Buyers

Active UK buyers in 2025-2026 are more selective than in the pre-CMA period, but the market is not closed: Vetopia entered the UK in September 2025 and launched under the VetThing brand, explicitly pitching an acquisition model that preserves local identity and ownership, while VetThing announced further UK acquisitions in 2026 including Arvonias Vets, Park House Vets and Stellar Vets before adding more sites in North Yorkshire, Northumberland, London and Somerset ^{15 16 17 18}. Pets at Home remains active mainly through de novo openings and partner transitions rather than large-scale acquisitions, while Medivet's 2026 sale of 50 Spanish sites to VetPartners signals portfolio pruning to refocus on UK growth rather than outbound expansion ^{13 19}. CVS is the clearest example of international expansion: it completed six Australian acquisitions comprising 14 sites in FY26 for A\$91.0 million/£45.6 million, following earlier Australian deals and minority buyouts, while UK acquisition appetite appears constrained by CMA scrutiny, leverage discipline and better relative white space overseas ^{14 20 21}.

04 Valuation Multiples and Deal Economics

Current veterinary transaction pricing remains in the 8x-15x EBITDA band, with Ackerman's Q1 2026 market update showing a 13.3x weighted average and 12.3x simple average across six deals, while top-tier assets achieved 16x+; that data is not UK-specific, but it is directionally consistent with reported upper-end pricing for scaled UK platforms such as VetPartners at roughly 13.9x implied trailing EBITDA in 2024 ^{22 23 11}. In the UK lower mid-market, advisers describe more compression for single-site and smaller practices, with premiums reserved for multi-vet, high-retention, subscription-heavy, referral-linked and property-light assets; recurring

care-plan revenue, vet retention, local density and clinical breadth remain the main valuation drivers ^{23 24 25}. Higher rates and tighter debt markets have reduced buyer aggressiveness versus 2021-2023, especially for leveraged PE-backed consolidators, but appetite has not disappeared; instead, buyers are underwriting harder on same-store growth, staffing resilience and post-remedy margin risk, which favors disciplined bolt-ons and partnership structures over broad auction processes ^{22 23 14}.

05 CMA Remedies and Outlook for Consolidation

The CMA's final report, published on 24 March 2026, concluded the market was not working well for pet owners and highlighted sharp price inflation, with average veterinary prices up 63% and first-year treatment expenses up 53% between 2016 and 2023 versus 32% CPI inflation ² ⁴. Remedies include mandatory ownership transparency, published price and service information, written estimates and itemised bills, medicine-choice disclosures, and caps on written prescription fees at £21 for the first medication and £12.50 for each additional medication in the same consultation; implementation starts with the Order in September 2026, large-business compliance from December 2026 or March/June 2027 depending on remedy, and broader RCVS data and comparison-tool milestones through September 2027 ^{26 27}. Commercially, the burden falls heaviest on large consolidators because they have the most to lose from price transparency, medicine margin pressure and easier local comparison, but the remedies stop short of forced divestitures, so consolidation should continue at a slower, more operationally disciplined pace with more emphasis on de novos, partnerships and niche entrants rather than another broad PE-fueled land grab ^{26 27 18}.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- UK first-opinion veterinary care is now highly consolidated, with regulation focusing on transparency and pricing controls over breakups.
- Veterinary transaction valuations remain robust at 8x to 15x EBITDA, with top-tier assets sometimes exceeding 16x.
- Future consolidation is expected to be cautious, favoring openings, selective deals, and niche expansion over large private equity-led rollups.

A Study on the UK first-opinion veterinary care market would cover ownership concentration, regulatory and pricing impacts, and M&A strategy and valuation trends — run it from your dashboard.